

Robots-Much Misunderstood



Maulik Jasubhai Publisher

WHAT IS THE first image that comes to your mind when you hear the term 'robot'? Most likely it will be R2D2 or C-3PO or even Hal (from *2001: A Space Odyssey*). If indeed 'robot' conjures up any of these images, then this term is actually jeopardising the future of robotics by a decade or more. The complexities that are implicit in these images are so high that no company in the world can make it a reality today.

The answer lies in simplifying the entire field of robotics. We need a new frame of reference for what our expectations from a robot are. In the industrial setup, we have made significant progress through simplification—we have robots that can weld and those that can lift heavy machinery. Then there are those that can test products for defects again and again and again... taking away the rote mechanical and menial jobs from us humans, dramatically increasing efficiencies and removing the element of human error.

Similarly, early computers started with the ability to perform simple

tasks with unerring accuracy, be it calculations or record keeping. The success of the computer industry was predicated on taking care of simple tasks before entrusting and developing machines to handle things more complex, such as cleaning dishes and washing clothes!

Technologies required to develop truly consumer friendly robots already exist. We have made progress in the motion sensors, voice recognition, and processing power of robots in the past several years. We have also seen significant progress on the AI (artificial intelligence) front. Carnegie Mellon and other universities have been able to develop this technology to such levels that a robot is able to drive a car at speeds of up to 20mph.

Then the obvious question is: So why have we not seen an explosion of the consumer robotics industry?

The future of consumer robotics depends on—knowing what the customers want and what they are willing to pay for it. This is easier said than done. An industry driven by the nerds and people who love robotics for its own sake may not help consumers meet their needs. Today, robotics is more like a solution in search of a problem. Too many robotics businesses are built as if they were part of a university programme where every graduate student wants to add that one last feature to the product, just because he or she can. Sounds familiar to the Silicon Valley of three decades ago?

Let us start simple... Define the need. That may be the first step for the consumer robotics industry.

**“We need a new
frame of reference
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A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Maulik Jasubhai'.